

A Canal Named for the Dead: Namba and Dotonbori

Osaka's most famous canal is named after a man who never saw it finished: Yasui Doton died fighting in 1615, weeks before his ditch became a waterway of theaters and teahouses. The same delta sent tsunami up its rivers twice in recorded memory, and a plain-spoken stone still asks passers-by to keep its ink fresh so no one forgets again. This dossier follows the canal, the quarter and the flood.



難波・道頓堀（大阪市中央区・浪速区）

In this dossier

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Written in English from Japanese library sources — chiefly books digitised by the National Diet Library — and official records. Superscript numbers point to the numbered sources at the end, with page frames for the digitised books.

A sandbar at the delta's edge

Namba sits on ground the Yodo River built. Across this district's study area, the Geospatial Information Authority's landform classification reads close to three-fifths of the natural terrain as sandbar and most of the rest as floodplain — low, flat land raised by centuries of river silt at the point where the delta's channels reached the sea. It was never solid ground so much as negotiated ground, and every century since has renegotiated it: Toyotomi-era engineers dug canals through it for defense and trade, Edo-period developers filled and platted its banks for houses, and the rivers that made the land periodically took some of it back.¹⁰

Osaka City's own account of its waterways starts the story with Toyotomi Hideyoshi, who had the Higashi-Yokobori canal dug as the outer moat of Osaka Castle in the 1580s and 1590s — the first of a network that would eventually lace the whole delta. Namba and Dotonbori were never inside the castle's defenses; they were the marshy, half-reclaimed land just beyond them, the kind of ground a city expands into once its center is full. Everything this dossier describes, from a private canal dug by a man who did not live to see it finished to a licensed pleasure quarter and a tsunami stone, happened on land that was still, in living memory, more water than earth.⁵

A canal dug in a dead man's memory

The waterway that gives this district its name began as a private venture. In 1612 Yasui Ichiemon, a man from Kuhoji village known to history by his Buddhist name Doton, obtained the Toyotomi house's permission to dig a canal from a branch of the Umezu River, recruiting Kuhoji farmers and paying for the work himself together with his two younger brothers and a relative, Hirano Toji. Osaka Prefecture's 1922 gazetteer and Osaka City's own 1915 history agree on what happened next: one brother died of illness in 1613, and Doton himself, having thrown in his lot with the Toyotomi side, was killed in the fighting when Osaka Castle fell in 1615. Of the four founders only Kyubei and Toji were left to finish the canal that same year, and it was the victorious commander Matsudaira Tadaakira — no friend of the Toyotomi cause — who, the sources say, named the finished waterway Dotonbori-gawa out of pity for its builder's death.¹³

The following year the canal's banks were surveyed and platted into what became known as the river's "eight towns," several of them, such as Soemon-cho and Kyuzaemon-cho, named after people in Yasui's own circle. Shimanouchi, the island of land the canal helped define, was still mostly empty in 1621, when Kyubei was made a chief city warden and ordered to fill it with houses; he took over the old spoil-yard on the canal's south bank, turned it into a lumber depot, and building followed. What had been a construction camp was, within a decade of Doton's death, becoming a neighborhood.¹³

Theaters, teahouses and a second canal

Entertainment followed the lumber trade. The 1922 gazetteer traces Namba's first licensed pleasure quarter to Nuriya-machi, nicknamed Rokken-cho — "six-house town" — for the six brothel-keepers who worked there; the playwright Chikamatsu Monzaemon set a scene of one of his puppet plays among its lantern-lit lattices. Osaka City's own 1915 history dates the canal's own theater district to 1626, when Yasui Kyubei — already at work developing Shimanouchi — obtained permission to move theaters to Dotonbori from the district then nicknamed Shibai-machi, "theater town," and to open a pleasure quarter alongside them, both meant to build up the new canal's trade. The trade later spread into Soemon-cho and Gozen-cho, and a mid-nineteenth-century licensing drive in 1857 authorised fifty new teahouses in Soemon-cho and twenty in Gozen-cho; Gozen-cho's quarter had faded out within a decade, but Soemon-cho's did not, and the name still marks a nightlife lane in Dotonbori today.¹³

Water kept reshaping the district's edges. In 1698 the engineer Kawamura Zuiken, better known for taming the Yodo River upstream, cut the Horie canal along the district's western side; the farmland taken for it was traded for reclaimed land at outlying islands belonging to Shimo-Fukushima and Noda villages, and the compensation land was platted into Sachimachi,

one to five chome — part of what contemporaries called the thirty-three towns of Horie Shinchī. The canal that had begun as one man's private venture in 1612 was, within a century, just one thread in a whole district built and rebuilt on borrowed and exchanged land.¹

A history the delta kept repeating

The same rivers that made Namba's land also, every so often, tried to reclaim it. Osaka's 1922 gazetteer strings together a chronicle of storm surges reaching back to antiquity: a storm surge recorded for the year 753 that damaged over a hundred dwellings and drowned more than five hundred people at Settsu Mitsu-mura; another in 817; a nationwide earthquake and tsunami in 887 that struck Settsu hardest of all; and two tsunamis in successive years, 1360 and 1361 — the second remembered locally as leaving no diver alive who had been at sea when it struck. A great storm in 1670 breached more than 4,000 ken of embankment and drove seawater over some 4,700 koku of farmland along the Kizu River mouth, sweeping large ships into the Tosabori, Denpo and Dotonbori canals.¹

A closer call, in institutional memory if not in scale, came on 6 October 1670, when a great storm breached more than 4,000 ken of embankment along the Kizu River mouth and the Shikanjima channel. Ninety-two houses belonging to the shogunate's own boatmen's corps were swept away and 121 of its retainers and foot soldiers drowned; more than 330 houses were destroyed across villages from Shikanjima to Kizu-mura and Imazaike-mura, some 4,700 koku of farmland went under salt water, and large ships were carried bodily into the Tosabori, Denpo and Dotonbori canals — the same three names that would recur, worse, less than four decades later.¹

The clearest rehearsal for what came later struck on 28 October 1707, in the earthquake known as the Hoei quake. The gazetteer's account has the sea bed roaring before the water came, a tsunami surging in from a sandbar at the Kizugawa river mouth, and small boats crowded with fleeing residents crushed under larger vessels the wave drove upstream as far as Nipponbashi; bystanders on the banks, it says, could only watch. Osaka's toll that day, by the same account, was 1,774 houses collapsed, 541 people drowned, 45 bridges destroyed or damaged, and more than 950 boats of all kinds wrecked or lost. It was a disaster large enough, one might think, that no one downstream would ever need reminding of it again.¹

The night the two river mouths flooded

They needed reminding within a century and a half. An earthquake shook Osaka on the night of 9 July 1854, and after weeks of aftershocks a far larger one struck on the morning of 23 December, damaging houses across Temma, Dojima, Nakanoshima and the western wards while sparing the higher ground of Uemachi. The real disaster came the next afternoon: a second great shock set the sea bed roaring again, and a tsunami surged up from a sandbar at the mouth of the Kizu River. Large coastal ships anchored in the rivers snapped their moorings and were driven upstream by the wave; on the Dotonbori canal every bridge as far as Daikoku-bashi was knocked down by the battering hulls, and small boats already crowded with old people, children and household goods — loaded there in fear of the earthquake — were crushed beneath the larger vessels as onlookers on the bank could do nothing to help. By the gazetteer's count for this stretch of river alone, 273 people drowned and ten bridges were lost; a separate national earthquake survey puts Osaka's citywide toll at roughly 1,500 vessels destroyed and 392 drowned.¹²

Local residents raised a stone to it the following year, and it still stands, now a city-designated tangible cultural property of Osaka, at Sachimachi 3-chome by the east end of Taisho Bridge. Its inscription, reproduced in full in the 1922 gazetteer, is written not in the gazetteer's formal style but in a plain, almost breathless voice, closing with the reason for its own existence: it notes that the Hoei disaster of 1707 was already a distant memory only 148 years later, so that few now living had heard of it, "and therefore so many again came to harm" in 1854 — and it asks that its own text be kept freshly inked, so that future generations, whenever the ground shakes hard near the sea, will remember to expect a tsunami and get to high ground.¹⁹

Embankments, storms and a canal district cut in half

River engineering became more permanent, if less poetic, as Osaka built its modern port. Between June 1898 and December 1899, in two contracted phases, the city's port office faced the north bank of the Kizu River near Chishima-cho with a stone-and-earth revetment more than 1,600 ken long, part of the same port-construction program that gave Osaka its modern harbor works. It did not stop the weather: the Muroto Typhoon of 21 September 1934 drove a storm surge back up the same rivers, as it did up the Ajikawa, and this dossier's companion Basic brief sets out the district's own memorial stones and the city's official casualty count for that day, and for the later storms that followed it. ^{4 11}

War reached Namba by air rather than by water. Osaka's prefectural police recorded, in an October 1945 tally still cited by Osaka's own peace museum today, 12,620 dead and 2,173 missing across the prefecture from the wartime air raids — close to 15,000 casualties in all, including Korean and Chinese residents among the dead — and a project begun in 2002 to identify every victim by name had reached 9,171 names by the museum's most recent count. Peace, once it came, still reworked the district's water: with the sewers finally doing the work canals once did, and with wartime rubble needing somewhere to go, Osaka City filled in most of its historic canal network after 1945. Of a network that had once included Temma-bori, Nagahori, Namba-shinkawa and a dozen others, only the Higashi-Yokobori, Hideyoshi's sixteenth-century castle moat, and the Dotonbori itself survive as open water today. ^{5 7}

Reading the ground today

Dotonbori's most photographed feature has its own layered history. The first Glico sign, a 33-meter neon tower with a runner in six flashing colors, went up near Ebisu-bashi in 1935 and was pulled down for its metal in 1943; the version visitors photograph today, switched on in 2014 with some 140,000 LED units, is the sixth in a lineage that survived the war only as an idea, rebuilt from scratch in 1955, refitted into a fountain of colored light in 1963, and redesigned twice more before the current sign went up. ⁶

War also reshaped Hozenji, the small temple a short walk from the canal whose moss-covered Fudo Myo-o statue is now one of Namba's most recognizable images. Air raids destroyed the temple's buildings in 1945, but the statue itself survived the fire; the custom of pouring water over it, which gave it both its covering of moss and its popular name, the Mizukake Fudo, took hold only after the war, as a way of drawing the district back to life. Between that statue, Soemon-cho's surviving name, and a tsunami stone at Taisho Bridge that still asks to be kept legible, Namba's ground carries more of its own history in plain sight than its crowds of visitors usually realise. ⁸

Timeline

1612	Yasui Doton begins digging a canal from the Umezu River at his own expense. ¹
1615	Doton is killed when Osaka Castle falls; the finished canal is named Dotonbori-gawa in his memory. ¹³
1616	The canal's banks are surveyed and platted into the river's "eight towns." ¹
1621	Yasui Kyubei is ordered to build houses on Shimanouchi's empty land, using the old spoil-yard as a lumber depot. ¹
1698	Kawamura Zuiken cuts the Horie canal; compensation land is platted as Sachimachi. ¹
1707 (28 Oct)	The Hoei earthquake sends a tsunami up the Kizu River mouth; Osaka counts 541 drowned. ¹
1854 (23–24 Dec)	The Ansei earthquakes are followed by a tsunami that sweeps ships up the Dotonbori and Aji rivers. ¹²
1855	Residents erect the two-river-mouths tsunami stone near Taisho Bridge. ¹⁹
1857	Soemon-cho and Gozen-cho are licensed to run new teahouses as a pleasure quarter. ¹
1898–99	The Kizu River's north bank near Chishima-cho is faced with a modern stone revetment. ⁴
1934 (21 Sep)	The Muroto Typhoon drives a storm surge back up the district's rivers. ⁴¹¹
1935	The first Glico sign is installed near Ebisu-bashi; it is removed for scrap metal in 1943. ⁶
1945	Air raids destroy Hozenji's buildings and much of the district; the city's toll reaches thousands dead. ⁷⁸
after 1945	Most of Osaka's canal network is filled in; only the Higashi-Yokobori and the Dotonbori survive. ⁵

Walking notes

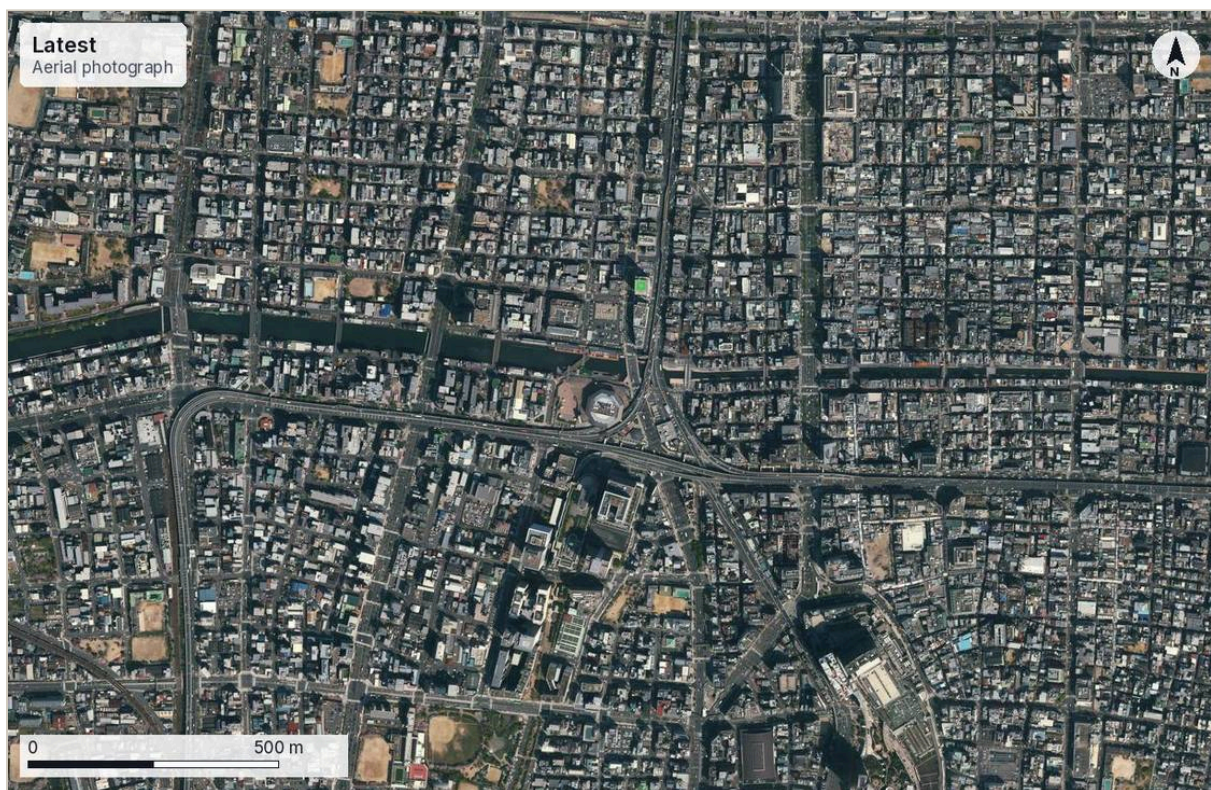
Places to stand and look, in walking order. Straight-line distances only; check today's access and opening before you go.

- 1 Dotonbori canal and Ebisu-bashi** 道頓堀・戎橋. The water itself is the 1615 canal, one of only two Edo-period waterways left open in central Osaka; the Glico sign above Ebisu-bashi is the sixth of a line going back to 1935.¹⁵⁶
- 2 Soemon-cho** 宗右衛門町. A licensed teahouse quarter since 1857, on a block named for a man in the canal-builder Yasui family's own circle two centuries earlier.¹
- 3 Hozenji Yokocho and the Mizukake Fudo** 法善寺横丁・水掛け不動. A moss-covered Fudo Myo-o statue that survived the 1945 air raids when the rest of the temple did not; the custom of pouring water over it began only after the war.⁸
- 4 The tsunami stone at Taisho Bridge** 大正橋・大地震両川口津波記碑. Erected in 1855 at the east end of the bridge, its plain-spoken inscription describes the 1854 tsunami and asks that its text be kept freshly inked so later generations do not forget, as Osaka had forgotten the 1707 disaster.¹⁹
- 5 The Kizu River embankment near Chishima-cho** 木津川護岸（千島町附近）. The riverbank here was faced in stone and earth in 1898–99 as part of Osaka's modern port works, replacing the informal banks the 1854 tsunami had overrun.⁴

The same ground, c. 1936–1942 and today



c. 1936–1942 aerial photograph — GSI Tiles *ort_riku10*, cropped and annotated by Japan Time Atlas. North is up; the frame is identical in both images.



Latest seamless mosaic — GSI Tiles *seamlessphoto*, cropped and annotated by Japan Time Atlas. Capture dates within a mosaic can differ from place to place.

How to compare. Anchor on features that rarely move — river banks, rail lines, shrine and temple grounds, main roads — then look for what changed around them. Differences in tone come from film, camera and season, not from the land itself.

The decades in between

Every further GSI series that covers the same frame, oldest first. Each series is a compilation: photographs within one series were taken on different dates, which is why seams and changes of tone can appear inside a frame.



c. 1928 · GSI Tiles *ort_1928*, processed



1945–1950 (US military photography) · GSI Tiles *ort_USA10*, processed



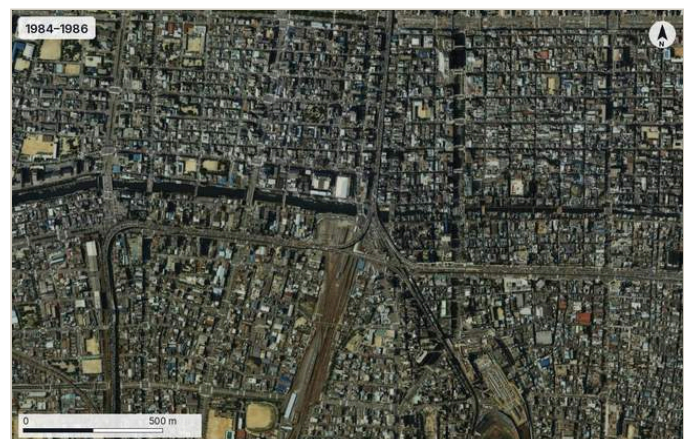
1961–1969 · GSI Tiles *ort_old10*, processed



1974–1978 · GSI Tiles *gazo1*, processed

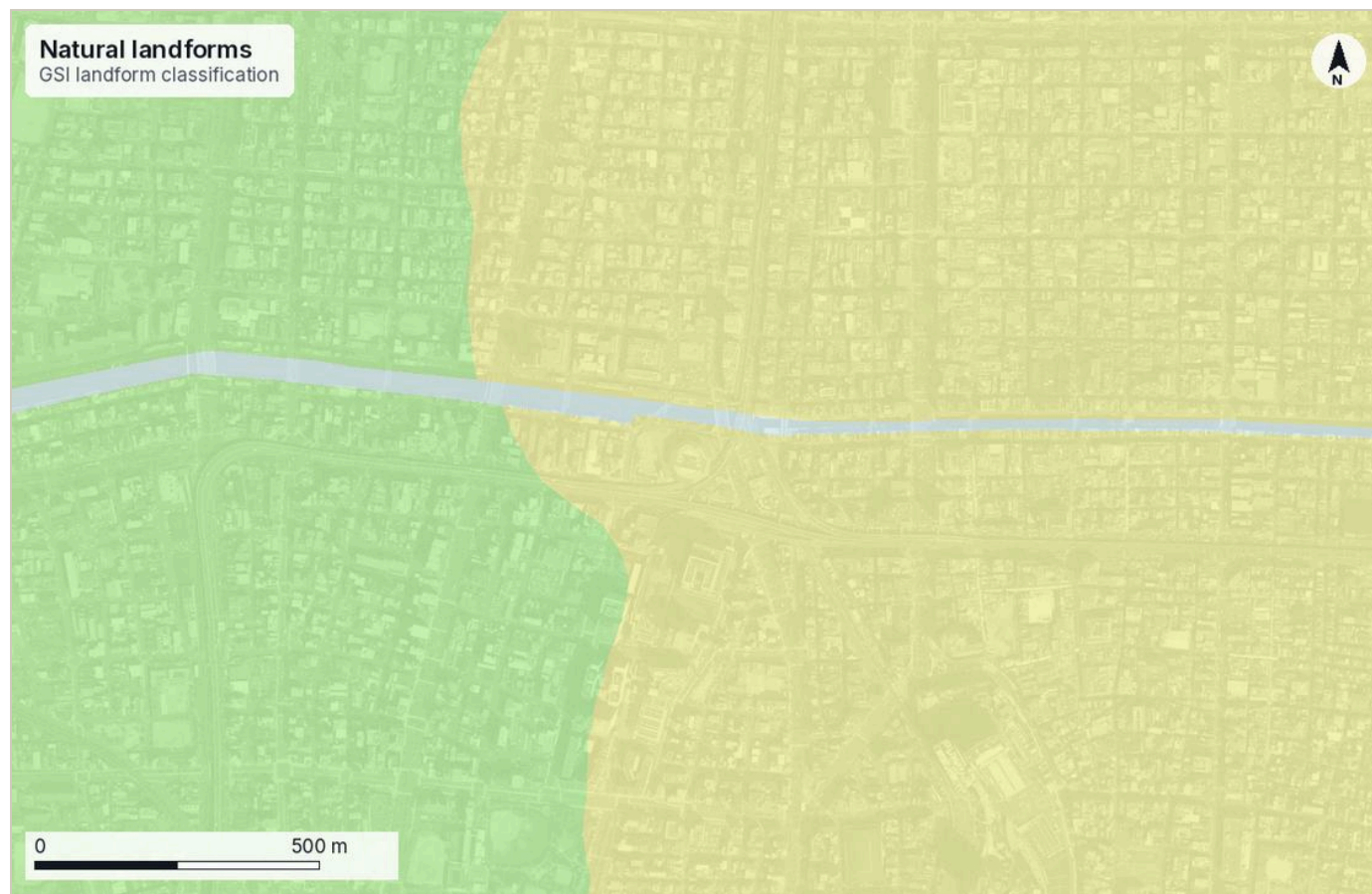


1979–1983 · GSI Tiles *gazo2*, processed



1984–1986 · GSI Tiles *gazo3*, processed

Rivers, shorelines and terraces



Natural landforms as classified by GSI, over a recent aerial photograph in gray. Dark blue outlines mark former river channels.

Sandbars and dunes 61%
 Water 2.0%

Floodplain and coastal plain 37%

What the main landforms mean

Sandbars and dunes (61%). Sandy or gravelly ground higher than its surroundings along present or former coasts, lakeshores and riverbanks, built by waves or wind. Usually escapes ordinary floods. Liquefaction tendency is somewhat strong on sandbars, somewhat weak on dunes and very strong at dune margins.

Floodplain and coastal plain (37%). Low, flat ground of little relief, built from sand and mud left by floods, or former seabed that emerged. River flooding. Ground is softer nearer the coast and shakes somewhat more; liquefaction tendency is strong on coastal plains and somewhat strong on floodplains. Storm surge near the coast.

Descriptions translated and condensed from GSI's landform-classification legend. They describe tendencies of each landform type, not the condition of any individual plot.

Fill, reclamation and the fields beneath the town



Hatching: man-made ground as classified by GSI. Teal outlines: former sea, river or pond. Dark blue outlines: former river channels.



GSI “Meiji-era lowland” data, traced from topographic maps of the 1880s–1900s; GSI warns that positions can be off by a considerable distance, especially in the Kanto and Kinki regions. Only low, wet or open ground was traced: towns, dry fields and forest of the period are left blank.

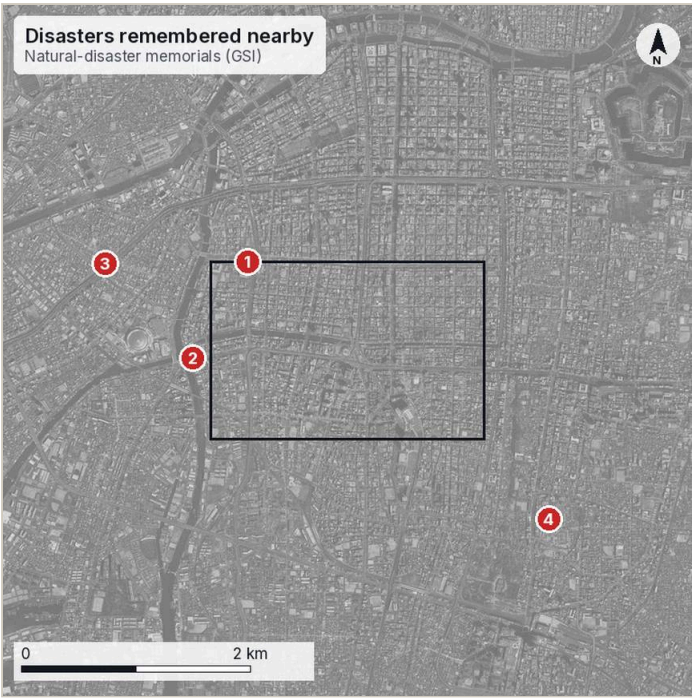
Man-made ground

No man-made ground mapped in this frame.

Meiji-era lowland

■ River, pond or sea 5.8%

Memorials to natural disasters nearby



Numbered memorials; the black rectangle is the study area of this brief. Frame 6 km across.

Memorial	Disaster	Erected	Distance
1 Flood defense monument recalling the storm surges of 1934, 1950 and 1961 水防碑	Muroto Typhoon (21 Sep 1934), Typhoon Jane (3 Sep 1950) and Second Muroto Typhoon (16 Sep 1961) · storm surge / other	1978	1.2 km
2 Stone recording the 1854 Ansei earthquake and tsunami at the two river mouths 大地震両川口津浪記	Ansei Tokai earthquake (23 Dec 1854) and Ansei Nankai earthquake (24 Dec 1854) · earthquake / tsunami	1855	1.4 km
3 Stone record of the 1934 Muroto Typhoon storm and flood in Kujo 暴風水害記念誌	Muroto Typhoon (21 Sep 1934) · storm surge / other	1938	2.2 km
4 Monument to the 1854 Ansei earthquake and tsunami 安政地震津波碑	Ansei Tokai earthquake (23 Dec 1854) and Ansei Nankai earthquake (24 Dec 1854) · earthquake / tsunami	1855	2.3 km

What the memorials record

1. Flood defense monument recalling the storm surges of 1934, 1950 and 1961. Nishi Ward in Osaka has been flooded again and again by storm surges brought by typhoons. Many lives and much property were lost: in Osaka City, 990 people died in the Muroto Typhoon of 1934, 211 in Typhoon Jane of 1950 and 6 in the Second Muroto Typhoon of 1961.
2. Stone recording the 1854 Ansei earthquake and tsunami at the two river mouths. After the Ansei Nankai earthquake of 24 December 1854, a tsunami struck people who had taken refuge in boats moored on the Aji, Kizu and other rivers, with heavy losses. The stone was erected as a warning to later generations, because the lesson of a similar disaster in the 1707 Hoei earthquake had not been heeded.
3. Stone record of the 1934 Muroto Typhoon storm and flood in Kujo. The Muroto Typhoon hit Osaka at about 8 am on 21 September 1934 with winds of 60 m per second and a storm surge of nearly 3 m. The city's dead and missing reached 990; 28 wooden school buildings collapsed and 269 pupils died. In Kujo, roof tiles flew like leaves and every house was flooded above floor level.
4. Monument to the 1854 Ansei earthquake and tsunami. People who took to small boats to escape the earthquakes of 23 and 24 December 1854 were swept upstream, boats and all, by a tsunami that surged into the mouth of the Kizu River, and a great many died. The inscription warns that a rumbling sea or disturbed tides are signs of a tsunami, and that people should evacuate.

Source: GSI Natural Disaster Memorials (自然災害伝承碑). English names and notes are Japan Time Atlas translations and summaries of GSI's Japanese descriptions; the memorials' own inscriptions may say more. "Erected" is the year GSI records for the monument.

Sources

1. 井上正雄 著 (Inoue Masao), 大阪府全志 巻之2 [Complete gazetteer of Osaka Prefecture, vol. 2], 1922; NDL frames 307, 308, 452, 453, 454. <https://dl.ndl.go.jp/pid/965799/1/308> (open online (NDL Digital Collections, no login)). Used for: The 1612–15 digging of the Dotonbori canal and Doton's death; the 1621 development of Shimanouchi; the growth of the Namba pleasure quarters; the 1698 Horie canal; Osaka's tsunami history from 753 to 1854, including the full text of the 1855 memorial stone's inscription.
2. 震災予防調査会 編, 震災予防調査会報告 第8号乙 [Report of the Earthquake Disaster Prevention Investigation Committee, no. 88-B], 1916; NDL frames 17, 18. <https://dl.ndl.go.jp/pid/974347/1/18> (open online (NDL Digital Collections, no login)). Used for: National context for the 1854 Ansei earthquakes and tsunami, including a citywide Osaka casualty and shipping-loss figure independent of the more localised count in S1.
3. 大阪市 (Osaka City), 大阪市史 第1 [History of Osaka City, vol. 1], 1915; NDL frames 150, 203. <https://dl.ndl.go.jp/pid/980475/1/150> (open online (NDL Digital Collections, no login)). Used for: Osaka City's own account of the Dotonbori canal's four founders, Doton's death in battle, and Matsudaira Tadaakira's naming of the finished canal, confirming the account in S1; frame 203's 1626 licensing of Dotonbori's theater district and pleasure quarter under Yasui Kyubei.
4. 大阪市築港事務所 (Osaka City Port Construction Office), 大阪築港誌 本編 [Record of the construction of Osaka Port, main volume], 1906; NDL frame 121. <https://dl.ndl.go.jp/pid/845738/1/121> (open online (NDL Digital Collections, no login)). Used for: Specifications and dates (1898–99) of the Kizu River's north-bank revetment near Chishima-cho, built as part of Osaka's modern port works.
5. コラム2 「水の都」大阪 [Column 2: Osaka, the "City of Water"], 大阪市 (City of Osaka). <https://www.city.osaka.lg.jp/kensetsu/page/0000009775.html>, checked 2026-09-28. Used for: The origin of Osaka's canal network from Hideyoshi's Higashi-Yokobori onward, and the postwar filling-in that left only the Higashi-Yokobori and the Dotonbori as open water.
6. 道頓堀グリコサイン [The Dotonbori Glico sign], 大阪市中央区 (City of Osaka, Chuo Ward). <https://www.city.osaka.lg.jp/chuo/page/0000645831.html>, checked 2026-09-28. Used for: The full sequence of six Glico signs from 1935 to the present, including the 1943 wartime removal.
7. 大阪空襲死没者名簿 [Register of the names of Osaka air raid victims], ピースおおさか大阪国際平和センター (Peace Osaka, the Osaka International Peace Center). <https://www.peace-osaka.or.jp/museum/list/>, checked 2026-09-28. Used for: The October 1945 police tally of Osaka's air-raid dead and missing, and the ongoing project to identify victims by name.
8. 都会の喧騒を一時忘れ、苔むす水掛け不動尊のもとで [Beneath the moss-covered Mizukake Fudo, forget the city's noise for a moment], ええやん！大阪商店街 (Osaka Prefecture shopping-district promotion site). https://osaka-shotengai-info.com/spot/nanchinakasuji_houzenji/, checked 2026-09-28. Used for: Hozenji's destruction in the 1945 air raids except for its Fudo Myo-o statue, and the postwar origin of the water-pouring custom.
9. 10. 大地震両川口津波記録 [10. The two-river-mouths tsunami-record stone], 大阪市 (City of Osaka). <https://www.city.osaka.lg.jp/kensetsu/page/0000009541.html>, checked 2026-09-28. Used for: The stone's 1855 erection date, its present location at Taisho Bridge, its inscription's request to be kept legible, and the city's own casualty figures for the 1854 tsunami.
10. 地形分類 (自然地形・人工地形) ベクトルタイル [Landform classification (natural and artificial) vector tiles], 国土地理院 (Geospatial Information Authority of Japan). https://github.com/gsi-cyberjapan/experimental_landformclassification, checked 2026-09-28. Used for: Classification of the study area as close to three-fifths sandbar and most of the rest flood plain.
11. 80年前に大阪を襲った室戸台風 [The Muroto Typhoon that struck Osaka 80 years ago], 大阪歴史博物館 (Osaka Museum of History). <https://www.osakamushis.jp/news/2014/tenjigae/140916.html>, checked 2026-09-28. Used for: The Muroto Typhoon's storm surge flooding roughly 27% of Osaka's built-up area and sweeping moored vessels far upstream on the Ajikawa, confirming the surge reached the district's rivers.

Further reading

- 浪速叢書 第12 (船越政一郎 編, 1927) — A compiled anthology of old Naniwa texts, including reprinted Edo-period accounts of Namba's twelve views and ten sights; useful for cross-checking the district's early-modern reputation. <https://dl.ndl.go.jp/pid/3436503> (open online (NDL Digital Collections, no login))
- 蘆分船：難波名所 (一無軒道治 著, 延宝頃、古版地誌刊行会編, 1924復刻) — A reprint of a 17th-century guide to Naniwa's famous places with its own Dotonbori entry (frame 20); listed here rather than cited because this session's OCR of its cursive text could not be read reliably. <https://dl.ndl.go.jp/pid/1246160> (open online (NDL Digital Collections, no login))
- 東区史 (大阪市東区役所 編, 1942) — A ward-level history covering the districts on the Dotonbori's north bank in more administrative detail than this dossier could verify from internet-open sources. <https://dl.ndl.go.jp/pid/1042191> (open online (NDL Digital Collections, no login))
- 明治大正大阪市史 (大阪役所 編, 1934) — Osaka City's own Meiji-Taisho-era city history, a natural continuation of the Edo-period material cited here into the era of the port works and early Minami entertainment industry. <https://dl.ndl.go.jp/pid/1236998> (open online (NDL Digital Collections, no login))
- 大阪大空襲 (大阪国際平和センター関連資料) — Peace Osaka's own victim-name database, for anyone tracing an individual air-raid casualty connected to this district. <https://www.peace-osaka.or.jp/museum/list/> (open online (NDL Digital Collections, no login))

Where a Deep Research request would go next

- **Original leasehold and water-register (mizucho) records for the Dotonbori "eight towns" and Sachimachi** — Osaka City Central Library's local history division and the Osaka Museum of History. Search the library's digital archive for 道頓堀川と water-register documents (mizucho) by town name; the museum's research division can advise on surviving Edo-period cadastral records.
- **Administrative and engineering records of the 1854 tsunami relief effort and the 1855 stone's erection** — Osaka Prefectural Archives (大阪府公文書館) and Osaka City's cultural properties section, which administers the stone's 2007 designation. Search the prefectural archive catalog for 安政大地震 and 津波 administrative files from 1854–55; contact the cultural properties section for the 2007 designation report.
- **Full contemporary records of the 1707 Hōei tsunami's effect on the Dotonbori and Kizu river frontage** — National Museum of Japanese History (Rekihaku) and Osaka Museum of History, which hold Edo-period disaster scrolls and diaries. Search each museum's collection database for 宝永地震 Osaka-related items; request viewing through their research-access procedures.
- **Individual company and shop records for the Dotonbori theater and teahouse district before 1945** — Osaka Museum of History and the Shochiku company archive (successor to several Dotonbori theaters). Contact the museum's business-history collections desk and Shochiku's corporate archive directly; some prewar playbills and account books are known to survive in private hands.
- **US Strategic Bombing Survey and 20th Air Force mission records for the March and June 1945 raids on the Minami/Namba area** — US National Archives (NARA), RG 18 (mission folders) and RG 243 (Strategic Bombing Survey). Search the NARA online catalog by Osaka and 1945; many mission reports and target photographs are already digitised.

Caveats

- Casualty figures for the 1854 tsunami differ by scope: this dossier's main NDL source counts 273 drowned along the Dotonbori/Namba river frontage specifically, while a national earthquake-history source and an official Osaka City page give citywide figures of roughly 392 and "over 600" drowned respectively; all describe the same event at different geographic scales.
- A reprinted 17th-century guidebook to Naniwa (Ashiwakebune, 1679) has its own Dotonbori entry, but this session's OCR of its old cursive typeface could not be read reliably enough to cite; it is listed in furtherReading instead.
- This dossier omits a historically documented but discriminatory place name for a small fort once standing at the Dotonbori river mouth, used during the 1614 Siege of Osaka; the name targets a premodern outcaste group and is not essential to the district's history as told here.

Digitised books are cited, not reproduced: the page frames let you open the same page in the NDL Digital Collections. Aerial photographs, landform and memorial data: GSI, processed by Japan Time Atlas. This experimental edition was checked against its cited sources on 2026-09-28 but has not had independent fact-checking.